

Shortenings

A shortening is a representation of a single word, typically in lowercase letters. Usually, the beginning or the end of a word is dropped; in rare cases, both the beginning and end of a word are omitted. The use of a period depends on whether the abbreviation is formal or informal. Occasionally, shortening results in spelling changes, as when *bicycle* is changed to *bike*.

advertisement → **ad**
 The first two letters produce this informal word.

in**flu**enza → **flu**
 The three middle letters make this informal word.

lat**itude** → **lat.**
 The first three letters create this formal abbreviation, which requires a period.

we**blog** → **blog**
 The last four letters create this informal word.

Contracted abbreviations

A contracted abbreviation occurs when letters from the middle of a word are removed. These words are usually related to a position or qualification. This type of abbreviation usually begins with a capital letter. A period is normally used at the end of a contracted abbreviation.

Doctor → **Dr.**
 Take out the middle four letters to get this abbreviation.

Junior → **Jr.**
 Remove the middle four letters to form this abbreviation.

Limited → **Ltd.**
 Remove the letters *imi* and *e* to make this abbreviation.

Sergeant → **Sgt.**
 Remove the letters *er* and *ean* to create this abbreviation.

Initialisms

An initialism is created from the first letter of each word. Each letter is pronounced separately and written in capital letters. Initialisms generally don't require periods between the letters.

United **S**tates of **A**merica → **USA**

British **B**roadcasting **C**orporation → **BBC**

Digital **V**ideo **D**isc → **DVD**

Acronyms

An acronym is a word formed from the initial letters of a group of words. It is different from an initialism because it is pronounced as it is spelled, not as separate letters. Acronyms are written in capital letters and without periods.

Acquired **I**mmuno**D**eficiency **S**yndrome → **AIDS**

North **A**tlantic **T**reaty **O**rganization → **NATO**

Personal **I**dentification **N**umber → **PIN**